

ANGELIC ALPHABETS

the spread of *charaktêres*



▲ Magical scholarship

Like other medieval Jewish kabbalistic texts, the 13th-century *Sefer Raziel haMal'akh* ("The Book of Raziel the Angel") contains magical symbols and other mystical knowledge, including the *Karaqtiraya* and star-shaped Seals of Solomon shown here.

Writing was at the heart of medieval Jewish magic, whether in the form of spells, curses, or protective words on amulets. Signs and symbols were a central part of written magic, maintaining secrecy and, it was believed, capturing the essence of ancient magic.

Some signs and symbols were developed by Jewish magicians themselves, but most derived from other cultures. The best-known import is *Karaqtiraya* (the Hebrew transliteration of *charaktêres*—an ancient Greek word for letter-like signs usually

formed from lines tipped with tiny circles). These were believed to have intrinsic mystical power. *Karaqtiraya* often appear in medieval kabbalistic texts, but their origins predate the 13th-century rise of Kabbalah by at least 700 years.

Karaqtiraya are thought to have entered the Jewish magical tradition around 1,500 years ago. No one is certain where they came from. Some speculate that they derived from Egyptian hieroglyphs, and others from Mesopotamian cuneiform, but the most likely

source is ancient Greek magical texts. Some of the signs resemble those found on Greek Magical Papyri and gems (see pp.32–35), while others appear to be letters of the Greek and Hebrew alphabets with circles added to their tips.

Because it was thought to be vital to copy magical writing accurately, these signs were preserved over the centuries—they endured in a way that ever-changing ordinary language did not. However, by the medieval period the story of their origins had been lost. *Karaqtiraya* are so similar to letters that Jewish scholars who studied them tried to decode them as parts of an alphabet, giving them Hebrew equivalents. Throughout the medieval period such scholars developed *Karaqtiraya* into a variety of alphabets, each associated with a specific angel, such as Metatron, Gabriel, or Raphael.

Secret codes

Jewish people were not alone in absorbing magical signs and alphabets, and *charaktêres* also entered the Christian and Muslim worlds. Leading church thinkers Augustine and Caesarius

IN CONTEXT

Symbols and seals

Arabic, Jewish, and Christian traditions cross-fertilized in the medieval era, and *charaktêres* appeared in all three. Their influence can also be seen in later occult symbols, which often combined elements from several traditions. The 18th-century demonology compendium pictured (right) draws on an eclectic mix of sources, and includes several magical seals. Each carries a label associating it with a particular demon, drawing on the medieval Arabic tradition that demons could be controlled or vanquished with written seals. The seals shown here are labeled as "Characters," and—although they are named for demons rather than angels—some of their shapes clearly show the influence of *charaktêres*.

This compendium, which claims to summarize "the entire Magical Art," includes seals for demons such as Beelzebub.

